

Any seasoned top-level executive would much rather have his mistakes pointed out to him early by a subordinate than have those mistakes make themselves painfully apparent later in the company's profit and loss statement.

Years ago, I had to make some far-reaching decisions regarding the operations of one of my American companies.

I was in Europe at the time and had received what I thought were all the needed facts in the form of letters, memoranda and reports from the company's management personnel. I didn't know, however, that a last-minute vitally important statistical report—which drastically amended all such reports previously sent from the U.S.—

had been lost in the mails. The report did not reach me, and thus, I unwittingly based my planning on incomplete information.

Arriving at what I considered were the correct decisions, I sent an instruction letter to the company's offices in the United States. A few days later, I received an urgent trans-atlantic telephone call from one of the firm's executives. He politely but firmly pointed out that I'd apparently failed to take certain important facts into consideration, and that if

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the program I'd outlined were implemented, the company would suffer heavy losses.

After talking at what seemed to be cross-purposes for several minutes, we both realized I had based some key calculations on outdated statistical information. A copy of the missing report was airmailed to me immediately and I revised my calculations, decisions and instructions.

The program I finally outlined eventually proved successful and profitable—thanks to the alertness of this company-management executive. I hate to think what the results would have been if all the firm's executives were the kind who never questioned their orders and carried them out "to the letter, regardless of the consequences!"